Alexithymia isn't the absence of feelings. It's having them at full strength with no reliable way to identify or name them. Whether this belongs under the neurodivergent umbrella is genuinely debated. Many people who have it identify as neurodivergent; some prefer not to. Both are reasonable, and nobody gets to decide it for you.

In plain words

Alexithymia means difficulty identifying and describing your own emotions. Physical sensations are noticed; the label attached to them isn't. It's common alongside autism — roughly half of autistic people have it — and it often explains things wrongly attributed to coldness or a lack of empathy.

What it can feel like from the inside

- Knowing something is wrong and having absolutely no idea what.
- Answering 'how do you feel?' with a description of your day instead.
- Realising three days later that you were furious on Tuesday.
- Feeling it in your stomach, your chest, your jaw — never in words.
- Being called unemotional while feeling a great deal, silently.

What people often get wrong

THE ASSUMPTION	WHAT'S ACTUALLY GOING ON
"They don't have feelings."	They have them fully. The naming is what's missing.
"They lack empathy."	Often the opposite — they absorb others' emotions and can't process their own.
"They're being evasive."	"I don't know" is frequently the whole, honest truth.
"It's the same as being autistic."	It commonly co-occurs but is separate, and plenty of non-autistic people have it.
"They just need to open up."	The information isn't being withheld. It hasn't been decoded yet.

What often comes with it

NOT COMPENSATION PRIZES — GENUINE, USEFUL THINGS

Steadiness in a crisis when others are overwhelmed.

Fair, unemotional judgement where that's needed.

Deep loyalty, shown in actions rather than words.

Strong observational skills about other people.

Honesty — no performance of feelings they can't locate.

What actually helps

- ☐ Ask about the body, not the feeling
- ☐ Give time — days, sometimes
- ☐ Watch actions rather than words
- ☐ Offer options: 'angry, or tired, or hungry?'
- ☐ Accept 'I don't know' as complete
- ☐ Don't demand emotional performance

If someone tells you this is them

HELPFUL

“Where do you feel it?”

“No rush — tell me when you know.”

“Is it more like A or B?”

LESS HELPFUL

“You must know how you feel.”

“Why won't you open up?”

“You're so cold.”

The feelings are all there. It's the labels that didn't come with them.

A friendly explainer written for the community — not a diagnostic tool and not medical advice. If you want an assessment, your GP is the place to start. Nobody experiences this identically, so take what fits and leave the rest.

Free to share — print it, forward it, hand it to anyone who needs it. More free guides, one per neurotype, at froglogic.co.uk